DAY 1

Start Where You Are



"The Lord is near to those whose hearts are wounded and helps those whose spirits have been crushed."

PSALM 34:18

You may have opened this book thinking about everything you need to change. You would like to pray more often, understand the Bible better, and live with a trust that does not disappear at the first difficulty. Those intentions may be sincere, but they can also conceal a demand: the belief that God will receive you only after your life is in order. So drawing near is always put off.

Psalm 34 offers another way. God draws near to the brokenhearted, to those who can no longer keep up the appearance that everything is fine. The psalmist does not describe someone who overcame every difficulty before seeking the Lord. He speaks of someone who needs help. Vulnerability is part of the encounter, rather than something that must be removed before it can happen.

You can bring this truth into an ordinary morning. The house is still untidy, work demands attention, and there is a difficult conversation you have been avoiding. None of that needs to be put on hold before prayer begins. You can bring God the life you have, including what you do not know how to resolve. An honest, simple sentence makes room for a relationship that trying to appear strong often prevents.

This does not mean treating your mistakes as though they do not matter. Drawing near to God also means recognizing what needs to change, asking forgiveness, and accepting responsibility. But acknowledging a wrong is different from endlessly condemning yourself. Guilt may point to something that needs repair; when it becomes the conviction that you can never begin again, it stops guiding and starts imprisoning. Grace lets you face the truth without giving up hope.

Perhaps you are returning after a long time. You may have been disappointed by people, fallen out of the habit of prayer, or drifted away gradually, without noticing when silence became distance. You do not have to rebuild everything in one afternoon. The journey can begin with a few attentive minutes, a Bible passage read slowly, and a prayer that is not trying to impress anyone. Small beginnings deserve care.

It also helps to let go of comparison. You see another person's confidence when speaking about God, but you do not know every question they have faced. Faith matures through different stories and at different paces. This book offers companionship for the coming days, not a measure of your spiritual worth. If a reading raises a question rather than an answer, you can still bring it to prayer.

Today, begin with what is true. Is there gratitude? Offer it. Fear or regret? Name them. Only weariness? Do not manufacture enthusiasm. God knows your whole life, and you can stop hiding the parts that most need care. The first step does not require knowing what every other step will be. It asks only for a willingness to draw near, here, on the solid ground of this day.

TO KEEP IN YOUR HEART

You can draw near to God with the life you have today, without waiting for everything to be in order.

TODAY'S PRAYER

Lord, I begin this journey bringing what is in me: gratitude, doubts, desires, and difficulties. Help me acknowledge my mistakes without believing they have ended my story with You. Give me courage to seek forgiveness, make amends where I can, and receive Your grace. Teach me to make room for You in the routine I have, even when it is unsettled. Help me stop comparing my journey with others and learn to take the next step honestly. Receive this beginning and guide my heart. Amen.